HELLBLAZER

John Constantine is 25 years old. During that time, the Alan Moore-created supernatural associate has battled demons and his own dangerous habits. We celebrate the character's enduring appeal

It's hard to believe but it's been 25 years since writer Alan Moore introduced the world to John Constantine in *Swamp Thing* #37 in June 1985. Based visually on former The Police frontman Sting, John Constantine was a regular supporting character in Swamp Thing, acting as the main protagonist's 'spiritual adviser'. Constantine was a very different character to what the comics world was used to: a working-class Englishman, flawed and manipulative but strangely appealing at the same time. The character's social class was key, as Moore explained to Wizard Magazine back in 1993: "It struck me that it might be interesting for once to do an almost blue-collar warlock. Somebody who was streetwise, working class, and from a different background than the standard run of comic book mystics. Constantine started to grow out of that."

It didn't take long for the trench-coated antihero to get his own title and *Hellblazer* #1 was launched at the end of 1987. Written by a contemporary of Moore's, the acerbic fellow Northamptonite Jamie Delano, the series was a take on urban horror that was unique to the marketplace and it was certainly the sort of title that DC had never brought to life before. Longevity is rare in the comic industry, so why has John Constantine made it to his 25th birthday? Delano had some thoughts on it when he returned to the character for original graphic novel *Pandemonium*, out earlier this year.

"I'm often asked this, and the truth is I don't really know. Primarily, I suppose, Moore's original character was intrinsically strong and imbued enough with inspirational potential to encourage most of the creators who have subsequently donned the trench coat to channel Constantine's idiosyncratic world-view with integrity and skill, developing a sensibility unique in comics… one that even assaults by Hollywood failed to destroy," he told us.

Delano – with the aid of artists John Ridgway, Richard Piers Rayner and many others – managed to turn the raincoat-wearing mage from a supporting player to a main attraction in his own right. He fleshed out his back story, gave him an interesting and varied supporting cast of his own and used the psychic landscape of a Thatcherite Britain to create a unique and distinctive territory for John Constantine. The title even gave artist Dave McKean a boost, predating his Sandman work and his cover images only added to the fact that *Hellblazer* was a title like no other being produced at that time.

Delano spent almost 40 issues on *Hellblazer*, broken up by a two-issue stint by future superstar Grant Morrison and a short run by Dick Foreman, and when he left the title, Constantine was living in London with an established and fleshed-out milieu distinct from *Swamp Thing*. It was Northern Irish writer Garth Ennis, just off a run on *Judge Dredd* in *2000 AD*, who steered his destiny next. The story, *Dangerous Habits*, with artist Will Simpson, was all about consequences in a classic *Hellblazer* vein: his chain smoking had caught up with him but, with this being a supernatural book, dying of cancer wasn't the only threat to the hero here. It developed the title beyond what Delano was doing with the character and was such a success that, after a single issue by John Smith, Ennis returned to *Hellblazer* with #52 and teamed up with artist Steve Dillon, another *2000 AD* alumni, on a run that lasted over 30 issues. With the addition of painter Glenn Fabry on covers, *Hellblazer* under Ennis and Dillon took the character to America, Hell, Northern Ireland, some of the dodgiest estates in England and back again. While humour was present in Delano's *Hellblazer* instalments, Ennis used a different sort of black humour to mark his run out from its predecessor. Constantine became so iconically connected with London during Ennis's run that the city almost became a supporting character. The readers also got to see a civil war in Hell and the beginnings of Constantine's battle with the First of the Fallen, plus romantic interest Kit was introduced here, a romance doomed from the start. There was something epic while remaining very grounded in Ennis and Dillon's stories.

The writers on the wall

Hellblazer's best writers and their greatest works


Jamie Delano
Hellblazer #1, Hunger


Grant Morrison
Hellblazer #25, How I Learned To Love The Bomb


Neil Gaiman
Hellblazer #27, Hold Me


Garth Ennis
Hellblazer #41, Dangerous Habits


Paul Jenkins
Hellblazer #89, Dreamtime


Warren Ellis
Hellblazer #134, Haunted


Brian Azzarello
Hellblazer #146, Hard Time


Mike Carey
Hellblazer #175, Red Sepulchre


Andy Diggle
Hellblazer #230, In At The Deep End


Peter Milligan
Hellblazer #250, The Curse Of Christmas

Constantine was originally based on Sting from The Police, but when he got his own title, DC had to change his look so that they wouldn't get sued.